

MH@MERICS Weekly W21-2026

I. Highlights

Caveat: nur stichprobenartig auf Qualität/Richtigkeit überprüft – Coverage nur bis 24. Mai 2026

Spotlight 1: Putin-Xi summit in Beijing

Putin visited Beijing 19-20 May 2026, five days after Trump's state visit (14-15 May). His 25th visit to China. Bilateral talks were held at Zhongnanhai. ~40 cooperation documents were signed (Sputnik / Ushakov: 42). Outputs include the main bilateral declaration ("Further Strengthening Comprehensive Strategic Coordination and Deepening Good-Neighborly Friendship") and a separate *Joint Declaration on a Multipolar World*. The Russian delegation included Lavrov, Ushakov, and energy-sector principals. The 2001 Treaty of Good-Neighborliness was extended at its 25-year anniversary. A joint press conference was held (MFA readout published). Side event: Russia-China Expo in Harbin.

Five key findings

- **New formulations in the 2026 joint texts.** The 2026 statements add three formulations absent from the 2022-2025 declarations: "polycentricity" (多极化的长期态势), "hybrid wars / proxy wars" in the *Multipolar World* declaration, and "elimination of the root causes" of the Ukraine crisis in the main bilateral text (was companion text in 2025).
- **Power of Siberia 2 again not signed.** Price, financing, and timeline remain open. Reuters, Bloomberg, BBC, WaPo and SCMP all report this as the headline non-deliverable.
- **Taiwan formula reverted in the text and absent from the press conference.** The 2026 declaration uses "China's territory" (中国领土). The 2024 and 2025 declarations used "inalienable part of the PRC" (中华人民共和国). The Taiwan question was absent from the joint press conference.
- **AUKUS removed; Strategic Stability statement not repeated.** AUKUS was named in every joint statement 2022-2025 (including the 2025 standalone *Joint Statement on Global Strategic Stability*). It is absent from the 2026 compiled passages. The 2025 Strategic Stability statement was not repeated in 2026.

- **2001 Treaty extended; "no limits" remains gone.** The 2026 statement title invokes the 2001 Treaty of Good-Neighborliness (睦邻友好) and the Treaty was extended at the summit. "No limits, no forbidden areas" (2022) has not been used in any joint declaration since.

Tension in the text

The 2026 declaration affirms "respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity of all states" while restating the "root causes" framing on Ukraine. The 2025 *International Law* declaration (co-signed with Russia) condemns "unilateral military interventions not based on...self-defense or SC resolutions".

Key sources (past 2 weeks)

Primary readouts

- Kremlin – Russia-China talks (2026-05-20)
- MFA – Joint press conference readout (2026-05-20)

Analytical

- FT Opinion – Gabuev: Beijing's unlikely bet on Russia may yet pay off (2026-05-22)
- Carnegie Politika podcast – Gabuev hosts, Yanmei Xie (MERICS) guest: After Putin's Visit to China, What Next? (2026-05-24)
- Foreign Policy – No Limits, No Good Options (2026-05-22)
- The Economist – How China quietly helps Russia in Ukraine (2026-05-20)
- Chatham House – Strategic duo endures, limits are clear (2026-05-21)
- FT – Xi 'law of the jungle' at Putin summit (2026-05-20)

Investigative

- Reuters – Russians covertly trained by China (2026-05-19)

News anchors

- WaPo – Putin fails to secure PS-2 approval (2026-05-20)
- NYT – As a weakened Putin follows Trump to Beijing, Iran war offers an opening (2026-05-19)

Spotlight 2: US-CN follow-on

(pending – Spotlight pass to draft anchor + condense ~57 sources)

Spotlight 3: Hukou / public-services reform

(pending – 5 hukou items parked + NDRC/Xinhua primary)

German China policy in context

GER

(pending – KEEPs flagged in curation: Euronews EU-defense, Reuters/Euronews German spy couple arrest, Politico EU-Germany trade clampdown, Tagesspiegel TU Berlin Uiguren event)

EU

(pending – KEEPs flagged: SCMP "sinking ship", FT trade weaponry, EEAS Kallas speech, EEAS Beijing ambassadors mtg, Brussels Signal Kallas remark, East is Read EU-CN data, SCMP CN-EU science partner)

Top Charts/Visuals

(pending – Data viz from Soapbox + MERICS chart toolkit)

II. MERICS

MERICS research and (media) insights | 1. Domestic economic situation/policy | 2. Politics and society | 3. Geoeconomics: trade, tech, finance, investment, industrial policy and competition | 4. Foreign policy / "Global China" | 5. Strategic implications and responses

MERICS research and (media) insights

(pending – MERICS Insights + Top Charts from 0 INBOX/W21-2026 MERICS Research and Insights.md)

MERICS publications + media insights detail

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III. International sources

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Chinese debates

(pending – Aisixiang/East is Read items)

1. Domestic economic situation/policy

WSJ: "China's economy unexpectedly weakens as Iran war fallout mounts", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **April retail sales grew only 0.2% YoY – slowest since December 2022 (March: +1.7%); industrial output decelerated from 5.7% (March) to 4.1%; fixed-asset investment –1.6% YTD:** NBS spokesman Fu Linghui flagged "spillover effects from geopolitical conflicts" – indirect Iran-war reference – complicating Q2 outlook.
- **Property: investment –14% YTD, construction starts –22% YTD, home sales by value –15% YTD:** Continued drag on consumer/business sentiment despite Politburo signals to stabilise housing.
- **Export sector still strong (+14% YoY April, AI-driven electronics):** Pinpoint's Zhiwei Zhang: "strong exports mitigated weakness in domestic demand, but not enough to fully offset". Iran war commodity-price spike could now squeeze manufacturer margins; factory-gate inflation hit a 45-month high.

Reuters: "Earthquake hits southwest China; thousands evacuate, buildings collapse", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Magnitude 5.2 quake in Guangxi killed 2, hospitalised 4, displaced over 7,000 in Liuzhou:** Thirteen buildings collapsed; railway authorities inspected line integrity; one person still missing as of Monday.
- **Communications, power, water, gas reported normal:** State media (CCTV / Xinhua) framing emphasised containment, in contrast to the coal-mine explosion days later in Shanxi.

Reuters: "China's property investment extends decline in January-April", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Property investment fell 13.7% in Jan-Apr, accelerating from -11.2% in Q1:** NBS data shows the sector's contraction deepening through April despite Politburo pledges to stabilise housing.
- **New construction starts (by floor area) collapsed 22.0% Jan-Apr after a 20.3% Q1 fall:** Developer funding shrank 18.4% over the same period, indicating no recovery in private credit access.
- **Property sales by floor area dropped 10.2% (Q1: -10.4%):** The mild improvement masks a continued absolute decline as buyers stay on the sidelines.

SCMP: "Chinese banks see stabilising margins as resilient economy offsets property risks: experts", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Chinese bank NIMs stabilised in Q1 2026 after six consecutive years of decline:** 11 of 25 listed banks that reported results posted year-on-year margin increases, with the sector average at 1.4%, according to EY.
- **PBOC rate cuts seen as unlikely given mainland economic resilience:** China's new energy technology and energy reserves reduce sensitivity to external shocks, supporting banks, an OCBC economist told SCMP.

FT: "China warns of 'severe' global conditions as economy shows weakness", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **China's April industrial output rose 4.1%, missing the 6% forecast:** Production slowed from 5.7% in March; retail sales came in at 0.2%, against analyst forecasts of 2%.
- **Fixed-asset investment contracted 1.6% year-to-date through April:** The reading reversed the prior month's 1.7% gain and came in sharply below analyst forecasts of continued expansion.

Economist: "What China can learn from Japan about escaping deflation", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **China's producer prices turned positive for first time since 2022:** Gulf war energy costs and the AI spending boom pushed producer-price inflation to 2.8% in April, the article reports.
- **Reflation remains confined to upstream inputs, bypassing consumers:** Factory-gate prices for consumer goods are still falling, retail sales grew just 0.2% in April, and workers lack bargaining power to demand wage rises.
- **Beijing treats wartime price jumps as an excuse to do less:** Unlike Japan's 2023 subsidies and tax breaks, Chinese officials are reluctant to cut rates or expand fiscal stimulus, the article argues.

Bloomberg: "China Home Price Slump Eases in Sign Market Is Stabilizing - Bloomberg", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **New-home price declines hit a one-year low in April:** NBS data show a 0.19% monthly fall across 70 cities, with resale prices posting their slowest decline since March 2025.
- **At least 16 cities eased property restrictions following a Politburo directive:** Measures include relaxed homebuying eligibility in Shenzhen and expanded mortgage subsidies in Guangzhou, according to Citigroup.

Bloomberg: "China's Aluminum Output Surge Tests Capacity and Demand Limits - Bloomberg", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Chinese aluminum daily output hit a record 129,000 tons in April:** Record margins and a global supply shock from the Iran war propelled smelters to maximum production, Bloomberg reports.

- **Domestic aluminum inventories doubled to a six-year high of 1.37 million tons:** Demand growth of only 1% - turning negative in January-February - left exports insufficient to absorb record output, according to analysts cited by Bloomberg.
- **Sector approaches the government's 45 million ton annual capacity ceiling:** Smelters are running up to 3% above nameplate capacity through technological upgrades to maximise profits before hitting the 2017-era regulatory limit.

Recodechinaai: "🤖 China's Robotics Industry Is Booming. A Pioneering Unicorn Just Collapsed.", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **CloudMinds' 22bn yuan valuation collapsed after government LP withheld pledge:** A local-government fund withdrew a committed 300m yuan tranche in late 2023, triggering insolvency despite real-estate holdings sufficient to cover all court-ordered debts.
- **Article argues today's robotics unicorns carry identical structural vulnerabilities:** Unitree and AgiBot share the same government-guidance-fund LP stack as CloudMinds and face the same 2026 test of demonstrated mass production and revenue.
- **Founder's core technical predictions arrived five years ahead of market readiness:** Huang identified humanoid form and sub-1,000 yuan joints in 2020; both arguments drew investment and applause only after 2024, when competitors had working prototypes.

Trivium: "Beijing targets pig farming overcapacity with new sow herd cuts", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **MARA cut its breeding sow target by 1.5 million to 37.5 million head:** China's agriculture ministry revised its pig production capacity management plan downward in its latest update, Trivium Markets reports.
- **The revision marks a repeated cycle of pig farming capacity intervention:** The article notes Beijing is targeting hog overcapacity "again," indicating prior reduction rounds have not resolved the structural imbalance.

Trivium: "Regulators tighten steel capacity controls", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **MIIT revised iron and steel capacity replacement rules on 18 May:** The updated measures govern how firms must offset new capacity additions, according to Trivium Markets.
- **Capacity replacement framework dates to 2014 overcapacity response:** Beijing originally introduced the rules to constrain net capacity expansion in the steel sector.

Eastisread: "35 and Out: Lin Wenlian's study confirms mid-career hiring cliff in China", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Job postings on five platforms cluster age limits at 35:** Analysis of 59.69 million listings confirms employers most frequently set 35 as the hiring ceiling, screening age before skills are assessed.

- **Employer-caused unemployment rises from 0.40% to 0.54% at the age-35 threshold:** The regression-discontinuity study holds productivity constant, attributing the jump to employer behaviour rather than worker capability.
- **Main driver is negative age stereotypes, not productivity decline:** The study finds employers view post-35 workers as less healthy, less proactive, and slower to adopt technology, prior to assessing individual performance.

SCMP: "P26-05-22, [Link](#)

- **State Council decouples social insurance enrolment from hukou registration:** Workers may now access social insurance in the city where they are employed regardless of official hometown registration, under measures announced Friday.
- **Transfer mechanisms across regions to be refined alongside enrolment reform:** The announcement also targets portability of social insurance relationships across provinces, addressing a longstanding barrier for China's 357 million migrant workers.

Bloomberg: "P26-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Cabinet guidelines link hukou exclusions to suppressed consumer demand:** The State Council directive frames migrants' lack of access to urban schools and health care as a structural driver of precautionary saving rather than spending.
- **No new funds committed; cities to absorb costs via fiscal incentive redesign:** Beijing proposed reweighting central transfers and land quotas toward population inflows rather than allocating fresh money - a formula that leaves cash-strapped local governments to bridge a gap a former central bank adviser estimated at 10 trillion yuan.

SCMP: "P26-05-23, [Link](#)

- **Policy framed as part of China's unified national market agenda:** Workers may now enrol in social insurance where employed, ending a hukou-based exclusion that blocked access to pensions and medical coverage.
- **Analysts cite urbanisation and property market gains as downstream effects:** Peng Peng of the Guangdong Society of Reform expects the reform to stimulate real estate activity and release consumer spending.

HKFP: "P26-05-22, [Link](#)

- **State Council guidelines explicitly tied to the 15th Five-Year Plan:** EIU analyst Ying Zhang said the document "very much reflects the spirit" of China's newly released five-year economic and social blueprint.
- **Mega-city uptake identified as the key test:** EIU's Zhang noted smaller cities already implement similar policies; whether Beijing and Shanghai follow is the pivotal open question.

X: "Post by @henrysgao on X", 2026-05-23, [Link](#)

- **Author argues reform is structurally undermined by local governments' fiscal stress:** Deeply indebted cities must expand migrant services without guaranteed central reimbursement, making substantive implementation unlikely, the commentary argues.

- **University quotas keep the biggest incentive for big-city hukou intact:** Elite university admission remains tied to hukou location, so migrants' core reason to seek formal registration goes unaddressed, the author argues.
- **Author warns cities will game new population-linked land-quota incentives:** China's track record of manipulating central incentive structures suggests local governments will manufacture inflated inflow figures to secure fiscal transfers and construction land.

2. Politics and society

Foreign Policy: "Why China is cracking down on elite education", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **China bans elite academic streams in favour of randomised placement:** Schools are ending gifted-student programs under an official ban, with class assignment shifting to lottery rather than test scores.
- **Elite school admission bribery reportedly reached \$130,000 in 2012:** Fees at Beijing's top state schools ran roughly 30 times the average urban household income, the article reports.
- **Author questions whether crackdown will reduce elite advantage:** The campaign may block middle-class students from advancement without dismantling the informal connections that benefit well-connected party families, the article argues.

SCMP: "China arrests 16 in drone hacking cases, vowing 'clean skies' crackdown", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **China's MPS arrested 16 for bypassing drone restrictions:** Suspects used technical means to circumvent altitude limits and no-fly zones, posing risks to public and national security, the ministry said.
- **Shanghai's largest case involved over 100 drones:** Police identified a 40-year-old man who developed restriction-bypass software from 2022 and marketed it via e-commerce platforms.

Github: "State Media Control Influences Large Language Models", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Commercial LLMs memorize Chinese state media at 3-10% completion rate:** When prompted with distinctive state-coordinated phrases, commercial models reproduce the expected continuation at rates matching or exceeding general web text.
- **Small state media corpus shifted outputs pro-government in 80% of cases:** The pretraining experiment used just 6,400 Chinese state-coordinated documents to make Llama-2-13b generate more favorable responses about Chinese leaders and institutions.
- **Cross-lingual favorability bias extends to Russia and North Korea:** Audit studies found the same language-dependent pro-government response pattern for Russian and North Korean institutions as for Chinese ones.

Foreign Policy: "China's Fallen Generals Are Getting Unexpectedly Harsh Punishments", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Wei and Li sentenced to permanent life imprisonment without parole:** A Chinese military court on 7 May handed both former defense ministers the harshest sentences ever imposed at their rank, with explicit bars on parole and commutation.
- **Author argues verdicts are floor-setting, not a closing chapter:** The piece contends that mid-purge timing and escalating political language signal a new sentencing baseline for He Weidong, Zhang Youxia, and others still awaiting trial.
- **He Weidong identified as the test for a Politburo-level sentence:** The author argues applying the same penalty to a sitting Politburo member would be historically unprecedented but risks losing the princeling network cooperation Xi still needs.

SCMP: "What do China's plans for 'comprehensive' new AI law mean for future of technology?", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **China's cabinet labels AI law 'comprehensive' for first time:** The 2026 State Council work plan replaced last year's "promote legislative work" with "accelerate comprehensive legislation for the sound development of AI."
- **Plan targets six regulatory domains for accelerated rulemaking:** The work plan lists data, computing power, algorithms, property rights, cybersecurity, and supply chains as areas for faster legislation.

ChinaTalk: "China's AI optimism isn't what it seems", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Author reframes China's high AI approval as anxiety-driven:** Stanford's 2026 AI Index records 85% Chinese AI positivity, which the author argues conflates fear of obsolescence with genuine enthusiasm.
- **1990s SOE mass layoffs created a "last bus" adoption psychology:** Xiagang displaced 24 million state-sector workers, teaching generations that missing the next transformative wave means permanent exclusion.
- **Author disputes Chinese AI adoption as state-directed and strategic:** Bottom-up fear, not policy coordination, drives adoption - generating frenzies prone to scams and oversupply outside the state agenda, the author argues.

BBC: "China coal mine explosion leaves 82 people dead", 2026-05-24, [Link](#)

- **Gas explosion at Shanxi coal mine kills at least 82:** The blast at Liushenyu Mine is China's worst mining disaster since 2009; 247 workers were on duty and 128 are now hospitalised.
- **Mine carried prior safety violations and mismatched underground blueprints:** China's National Mine Safety Administration listed Liushenyu as a "severe safety hazard" in 2024, and water buildup and inaccurate mine plans further impeded rescue operations.
- **State Council ordered investigation; management reportedly detained:** Officials promised "severe punishment" for those found responsible, and

Tongzhou Group suspended production at all four of its mines following the blast.

3a. Tech, AI, semiconductors, biotech & innovation

Reuters: "Trump postpones AI executive order, cites need to compete with China", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Trump shelved the AI executive-order signing scheduled for Thursday, citing dislike of "certain aspects":** CEOs were already assembled at the ceremony when the postponement was announced.
- **Draft EO would have created a voluntary pre-release framework for AI developers + tasked advanced models with hardening federal/critical-infrastructure cyber defences:** Anthropic's Mythos was cited as part of the cyber-risk rationale.
- **Industry pushback concern:** Order could slow model rollout or force behavioural changes – industry argument that any constraint hits the competitive position vs Chinese labs.

Straits Times: "China will open its market to AI chips from US, Nvidia's CEO Jensen Huang says", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Chinese firms withdrew H200 orders despite US export clearance:** Nvidia received orders and US licences but Chinese companies later said they could not fulfill purchases, owing to Beijing's push for semiconductor self-sufficiency, the article reports.
- **Trump-Xi summit produced no concrete chip access commitments:** Huang said he expects China's market to open "over time" while Trump said H200 chips "came up" in Beijing talks without elaborating further.

Diplomat: "China's plan for winning the AI race hinges on the token economy, not chips", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Chinese open-weight models matched US coding benchmarks at one-sixteenth the price:** MiniMax M2.5 scored 80.2% on SWE-Bench against Claude Opus 4.6's 80.8%, at \$0.30 versus \$5 per million input tokens.
- **Chinese models surpassed US rivals on OpenRouter by late February 2026:** Platform data show Chinese models at 61% of weekly token consumption, with US firms identified as the heaviest users in agentic workflows.

ce.cn: "European business leaders see practical AI cooperation opportunities with China", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **European chambers identify medical tech and automation as top AI cooperation sectors:** Representatives of Danish, French, and British chambers cited China's speed of application and scale as assets for joint research, testing, and product development.
- **Governance and data security named as conditions for cooperation:** Multiple participants called for regulatory guardrails on AI, with Spain's Labour

Minister and French chamber president stressing algorithm oversight and data protection as prerequisites for deeper engagement.

Bloomberg: "Taiwan seeks to detain three in Nvidia smuggling crackdown", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Three detained in Taiwan over Nvidia chip smuggling to China:** Prosecutors allege the trio forged export documents on 50 Super Micro AI servers bound for China, violating US trade rules.
- **Taiwan's first smuggling prosecution signals shift under President Lai:** Taipei used domestic fraud statutes rather than US-style chip export restrictions to target the diversion of AI hardware to China.

ChinaTalk: "The Empire of Wuxi", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **WuXi estimated to supply roughly a quarter of all US drugs:** A 2024 Biotechnology Innovation Organization survey found 79% of US biopharma companies hold at least one contract with a Chinese CDMO, the article reports.
- **BIOSECURE Act dropped explicit WuXi naming in its final 2026 NDAA form:** WuXi AppTec briefly appeared on the Pentagon's 1260H "Chinese military companies" list before the update was withdrawn from the Federal Register.
- **Authors argue no single country can absorb WuXi's multi-layer role:** India leads in small-molecule generics but not complex biologics; South Korea's Samsung Biologics covers biologics but not chemistry services.

Nikkei: "China chipmaker CXMT logs 1,688% profit surge amid global memory crunch", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **CXMT reported 1,688% profit surge and filed for a STAR Market IPO:** China's top DRAM maker posted 24.7 billion yuan net profit in Q1 2026 on revenues of 50.8 billion yuan, driven by rising global DRAM prices.
- **CXMT claims 7.67% global market share as PC makers qualify its chips:** HP, Dell, Asus and Acer are open to sourcing from CXMT amid memory shortages, with the company now ranked fourth globally by Omdia.

WSJ: "Tesla Announces Rollout of Fully Self-Driving Tech in China - WSJ", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Tesla launched FSD Supervised in China following regulatory approval:** The rollout comes after years of efforts to gain clearance and coincided with Elon Musk's Beijing visit during the Trump-Xi summit.
- **Analysts expect FSD entry to accelerate Chinese automakers' autonomous driving development:** Only XPeng is assessed as close to Tesla's capability level, with broader competition anticipated.

Economist: "AI super-apps are remaking China's internet", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **Alibaba, ByteDance, and Tencent each integrated AI chatbots into flagship super-apps in May 2026:** Tencent founder Pony Ma warned of a "land grab" for agentic services as competition between the three intensified, The Economist reports.
- **Alibaba's Chinese e-commerce operating profit fell 40% year-on-year in Q1 2026:** Tech giants see agentic AI as a growth avenue while consumer spending remains anaemic and cloud expansion demands heavy capital investment.
- **Over 600 million Chinese have used agentic apps, but monetisation remains unresolved:** A ByteDance-ZTE AI smartphone failed after Alibaba and Tencent blocked its access to their payment platforms.

3b. Trade, industry, finance, energy & supply chains

Nikkei: "Japan's auto industry plots new road map to counter BYD threat", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Honda withdraws 100%-electric-by-2040 target, scraps Canadian EV plant + Sony Afeela JV, posts first full-year net loss since 1957:** Cited misread of hybrid demand and Trump policy headwinds; analysts pin underlying cause on Chinese OEM competition.
- **BYD global share jumped from 0.6% (2020) to 5.3% (2025), overtaking every major Japanese maker except Toyota; Geely now ahead of all Japanese except Toyota at 4.5%:** Nissan posted two consecutive years of net losses; Toyota profit expected to decline for third straight year.
- **Industry strategist: Chinese brands' edge = low-cost production + digitalisation + advanced EV technology, across 200+ marques targeting young/entry-level buyers in 190 markets:** Japanese OEMs' traditional strengths (reliability, ICE cost-effectiveness, after-sales) don't compete in the segment Chinese makers created.

Reuters: "EU shortlists tungsten, rare earths for first stockpile to curb reliance on China", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **EU shortlist names tungsten, rare earths, gallium for first joint critical-minerals stockpile; magnesium, germanium, graphite likely on the final mix:** 10 of 12 elements on the list also appear on NATO's defence-critical list.
- **Rotterdam, Porto Marghera, Trieste in storage-hub talks:** Italy's industry minister Urso publicly confirmed Mediterranean-hub assessment. Ten EU member states involved in working groups led by Italy, France and Germany.
- **France's G7 presidency has elevated diversification; permanent secretariat under negotiation:** Framed as one of the EU's most concrete steps to insulate the bloc from Beijing's leverage in critical-minerals supply.

CER: "China shock 2.0: The cost of Germany's complacency", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Setser/Tordoir attribute ~40% of Germany's GDP shortfall vs pre-pandemic path to lost export demand from China:** 6% gap vs trend is "Brexite-magnitude"; analysis credits China-displacement, not EU bureaucracy or energy prices, as the dominant cause Berlin keeps avoiding.
- **China's manufacturing surplus is roughly 1pp of world GDP higher than pre-2020 and IMF puts RMB undervaluation at 16% (authors argue closer to 30%):** Beijing intervenes against appreciation while sustaining 4.4% GDP industrial subsidy spend (~\$800bn/yr), 3-9x OECD-economy norms.
- **Germany has lost over 400,000 export-linked jobs to China since 2021 peak; aircraft exports to China down 50%, capital-goods balance flipped to deficit mid-2025:** French planners estimate up to 70% of German manufacturing output is exposed to Chinese competition over the medium term.
- **Authors call for a European "Section 301" instrument, broader safeguards, tighter Union-content rules in the Industrial Accelerator Act, and earmarked CN-tariff revenues for retaliation-compensation fund (~€45bn/yr potential):** Frames Germany's hesitation as ceding leverage to France/Brussels and risking irreversible deindustrialisation.

Reuters: "China says rare earth controls lawful, will cooperate with US on 'reasonable' concerns", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **MOFCOM defends April 2025 export controls as "legitimate and lawful":** Beijing committed only to address US "reasonable and lawful concerns", refusing the dismantling Washington signalled in Busan six months ago.
- **April yttrium oxide exports to US fell to 10 tons from 60 tons in March:** Pre-control shipments averaged ~30 tons/month over 13 months; post-control average is 8 tons. Aircraft engine and turbine blade supply chains hit hardest.
- **Washington tacitly accepts the new export regime:** Both the WH and USTR Greer flagged rare earth concerns post-summit without securing reversal. Reuters frames as new status quo: US accepts controls, CN cooperates only on case-by-case licensing.

Nikkei: "Japan's Nidec to end China JV as it scales back EV drive parts", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Nidec to dissolve China e-axle JV with Guangzhou Automobile Group:** Japan's Nidec will exit both its Chinese and European electric axle joint ventures, citing overcrowded competition in the segment.
- **CEO frames withdrawal as strategic pivot away from expansion-era projects:** President Kishida described the e-axle market as a "red ocean," signalling a shift from growth to structural reform.

Bloomberg: "Nissan eyes exporting Chinese-made electric vehicles to Canada", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Nissan considers exporting Dongfeng JV cars to Canada:** Nissan's Americas head confirmed the company is assessing exports of China-made EVs after Canada opened a 49,000-unit annual quota in January.

- **Nissan CEO targets up to 300,000 annual exports from China:** Initial shipments of the N7 EV sedan and Frontier Pro pickup are bound for Latin America, with Canada a potential addition.

FT: "The Beijing-Brussels barney", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Trump-Xi summit established "boards of trade and investment":** Beattie argues the framework signals a turn toward managed trade - procurement targets and centrally directed deals - rather than multilateral liberalisation.
- **Author compares approach to Reagan's 1980s Japan agreements:** Those deals raised consumer prices, redistributed profits to foreign firms, and failed to cut imbalances; Beattie argues Trump's version will likely perform worse given weaker institutional capacity.
- **Beijing ordered Chinese entities not to cooperate with EU's FSR probe into Nuctech:** China cited new economic security powers introduced last month, calling the investigation an illegitimate assertion of extraterritorial jurisdiction; the Commission rejected the characterisation.

SCMP: "Despite summit pledges, don't expect US-China trade to improve", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Author argues summit pledges mask continued US pressure:** Zhou Xiaoming (CCG fellow, former Chinese diplomat) contends Washington's pattern of diplomatic promises paired with policy pressure will block bilateral trade improvement.
- **Multiple US restrictions enacted despite summit diplomacy:** The USITC launched a PNTR revocation probe, Treasury restricted AI/quantum/semiconductor investment, and nine Chinese firms were blacklisted days before the Beijing meeting.

Guardian: "Fears of new China shock as EU industry's reliance on imports grows", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Chinese suppliers dominate EU imports of key industrial components by volume:** China accounts for 88% of EU amino acid imports and 96% of polyhydric alcohols, Soapbox trade data shows.
- **Germany shed 22,000 machinery jobs last year amid Chinese import pressure:** Trade groups attribute losses to Chinese products priced 30-50% below European equivalents, exacerbated by a potentially 40%-undervalued yuan.
- **EU's main legislative tools against import dependence not in force before 2027:** The Industrial Accelerator Act and updated Cyber Security Act leave Brussels without effective remedies for the current import surge, the article reports.

FT: "How China enables American domination", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Renminbi holds only 2% of global central bank reserves:** The author argues this lag - 30 to 40 years behind historical precedent for rising powers - reflects China's uniquely closed financial system among major economies.

- **Capital controls trap domestic liquidity inside China's "walled economy":** According to the author, Beijing fears that easing controls would unleash capital flight, keeping foreign ownership of Chinese stocks and bonds below 5%.
- **Dollar dominance gives the US financial leverage China cannot replicate:** The author argues US control of the global financial network enables persistently large twin deficits and the power to cut rivals off from the payment system.

Nikkei: "China's investment in Europe hits 7-year high, still far from peak", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Chinese FDI in Europe reached €16.8bn in 2025, a seven-year high:** The 67% year-on-year rise was driven by M&A (+89%) and greenfield investment (+51%), with 42% directed at the EV supply chain, according to the Rhodium-MERICS report.
- **Exports remain Chinese firms' preferred channel despite rising FDI:** The report finds that anti-dumping and countervailing duties cover only 9% of China's exports to Europe, leaving the single market broadly open.
- **Newly announced transactions fell sharply to €5.2bn versus €16.9bn in 2023:** The report attributes subdued pipeline activity to Beijing's focus on domestic capacity retention, an undervalued yuan, and weak profit margins at home.

Nikkei: "China, US to seek lower tariffs on \$30bn worth of goods each: Beijing", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **US and China each commit to identify \$30bn in goods for reduced tariffs:** The "board of trade" framework agreed at the Trump-Xi summit covers roughly 7% of China's exports to the US, according to China's Ministry of Commerce.
- **Agricultural products included in principle; Boeing deal confirmed:** Beijing confirmed a 200-aircraft Boeing purchase and said farm goods will be part of the reciprocal tariff framework, while not addressing the \$17bn in annual US agricultural purchases cited by Washington.

Nikkei: "Stellantis and Dongfeng form EV joint venture for Europe", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Stellantis and Dongfeng sign 51-49 JV to sell Chinese EVs in Europe:** The venture will distribute Dongfeng's premium Voyah-branded NEVs in selected European markets and explore production at Stellantis' Rennes plant in France.
- **Deal expands existing Stellantis-Dongfeng ties beyond China:** A separate agreement signed last week already has Dongfeng manufacturing Jeep and Peugeot models in China; Dongfeng retains a small equity stake in Stellantis from the earlier PSA partnership.

Nikkei: "US reveals case against Chinese shipping container 'cartel' after Trump-Xi summit", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **US DOJ charges four Chinese firms with container price-fixing:** The companies produce approximately 95% of the world's dry shipping containers and allegedly conspired to restrict supply from late 2019 to early 2024.

- **Defendants doubled container prices and increased profits roughly 100-fold:** The cartel limited production line hours, installed surveillance cameras to enforce the limits, and agreed not to build new factories, according to the indictment.
- **Indictment unsealed days after Trump-Xi Beijing summit:** The January 2026 filing was made public less than a week after Trump's first presidential visit to China since 2017, which both sides framed as a trade reset.

Nikkei: "Chinese EV makers awaken Western rivals' zombie production lines", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Chinese EV firms repurpose idle Western production lines to sidestep tariffs:** Stellantis is sharing Spanish and French plants with Leapmotor and Dongfeng; Geely is reportedly taking over a spare Ford line in Spain.
- **Localisation raises cost and compliance risks alongside tariff benefits:** Citigroup's European autos analyst notes Chinese firms will face expensive European labour and mandatory local content rules once operating on the continent.

Nikkei: "Japan's NTN to mass-produce EV bearings in China", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **NTN to mass-produce EV insulated bearings at Shanghai plant from 2027:** The Japanese bearings maker will sell the components to Chinese and other automotive companies, with prototype production beginning this month.
- **NTN targets a fivefold increase in global production capacity by 2035:** The Shanghai expansion complements existing Japanese mass production in Iwata, Shizuoka, launched last year.

FT: "Iran war opens 'golden window' for China's renminbi", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **CIPS average daily volumes hit a record Rmb920.5bn in March:** Transactions briefly spiked to Rmb1.22tn in early April with nearly 42,000 in a single day, state media reported.
- **Sanctioned sellers force oil buyers to settle in renminbi:** Russia and Iran cannot receive dollar payments, leaving importers such as India with renminbi as their only viable option, according to analysts cited by the FT.
- **Renminbi's global oil trade share remains in the single digits despite the surge:** FT calculations and analyst estimates put the Chinese currency at 3-8% of global oil trade, against the dollar's roughly 80%.

Euobserver: "China threatens retaliation over new EU tool to curb Chinese 'overcapacity'", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Beijing warned of "resolute countermeasures" if Brussels acts on overcapacity:** Spokesperson He Yadong argued EU export surpluses in autos and pharmaceuticals should equally qualify as overcapacity, urging dialogue over restriction.

- **EU-China trade deficit hit €360bn in 2025 with further widening forecast:** Germany's bilateral shortfall doubled to \$25bn last year as Brussels cites China's 30% global production share against just 13% consumption.

Lowy Institute: "Trump and Xi's economic ceasefire is holding – just", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Author frames shallow outcome as product of mutual weakness:** Trump's political unpopularity and Xi's deflationary pressures left both sides unable to extract meaningful concessions, the article argues.
- **Iran war energy shock compounds bilateral economic fragility:** Asia's energy price spike suppresses Chinese consumption recovery while US inflation erodes real wages, the article reports.

Australian: "Northern Minerals hit by Chinese investor divestment order | The Australian", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Taiwan delegation sought entry into Northern Minerals after Chalmers' divestment order:** Following Beijing's forced exit, Taipei moved to secure a stake as part of efforts to build a "non-Red supply chain," according to The Australian.
- **Australian government action on Chinese rare earth holdings opened direct Taiwan investment talks:** Canberra's divestment cleared the path for non-Chinese critical mineral capital in the Western Australian project, the article reports.

PIIE: "China's mercantilist squeeze on developing countries", 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **China crowds developing countries out via three trade channels:** Global market competition, domestic displacement, and limited Chinese market access collectively constrain low-income countries' industrialization opportunities, the paper argues.
- **Scale of lost exports and jobs is historically unprecedented:** The authors estimate hundreds of billions of dollars in forgone exports and manufacturing employment across low- and middle-income countries.
- **Renminbi undervaluation identified as a potential amplifying factor:** Macro indicators on wages, productivity, and exchange rates suggest currency distortions contribute to China's dominance, potentially foreclosing the traditional manufacturing-led development path for poorer economies.

4. Foreign policy / "Global China"

Telegraph: "Anti-China government installed in strategic Solomon Islands", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **PM Matthew Wale, sworn in 5/16, opposes the 2022 China security pact and named Beijing-critics to FM (Rick Hou) and planning (Rick Kenilorea,**

IPAC member) roles: Election widely framed as referendum on Beijing-Canberra alignment.

- **Wale publicly reaffirmed One China principle to Cai Weiming while urging Canberra to "think big and think long term":** HMS Tamar docked in Honiara same week; UK + Australia courting Pacific.
- **Background: SI switched recognition from Taipei to Beijing in 2019; Chinese police installed "surveillance village" biometric+CCTV programmes:** Telegraph notes widespread allegations of bribery accompanied the 2019 switch. Former Aus HC Batley judges full reversal of CN ties unlikely.

Reuters: "Taiwan says China's military actions are greatest source of regional instability", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Premier Cho Jung-tai (eve of Lai's 2nd-year anniversary) called PRC the "greatest source of regional unease and instability":** Cited PLA activity in Taiwan Strait, Indo-Pacific, SCS and around Japan affecting navigational safety.
- **PRC Navy confirmed Liaoning carrier group deployed to Western Pacific for live-fire drills "in accordance with annual plan":** MND released photos including a J-16 trailed by a Taiwanese F-16 in response.
- **Lai impeachment motion failed in parliament same day:** Opposition lacks two-thirds majority; Cho restated ROC's "sovereign and independent country" status and reiterated dialogue offer "on equality and dignity".

Reuters: "China's Xi may visit North Korea as early as next week, Yonhap reports", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Yonhap (citing senior ROK gov source) reports a likely Xi visit to Pyongyang late-May or early-June:** A Chinese security/protocol advance team was reportedly in Pyongyang recently.
- **Visit positioned as Xi mediation between Kim and Trump:** Trump met Kim three times in first term and said he is open to another meeting; ROK foreign ministry signalled hope that CN-DPRK exchanges contribute to peninsula stability.
- **Bilateral context:** First Xi DPRK visit since the COVID-era cooling; Kim attended Beijing's military parade last year alongside Xi and Putin.

Reuters: "Taiwan tracks second Chinese 'combat' patrol in a week, sends ships and jets to monitor", 2026-05-26, [Link](#)

- **PLA conducted second "joint combat readiness patrol" inside one week around Taiwan:** 21 aircraft including J-16 fighters and drones plus warships, after a prior patrol on the eve of Lai's second-year speech.
- **Coast guard standoff at Pratas Islands and 100 PLAN ships in first island chain reported the same weekend:** NSC SG Joseph Wu publicly disclosed the deployment scale, signalling Taipei's higher willingness to surface PLA activity.
- **Taiwan's MND released its own imagery in response:** F-16 photos of two J-16s trailing a Y-20 refueller and a navy sailor watching the warship Yinchuan – a deliberate departure from purely text-based PLA-activity readouts.

**Straits Times: "Norway arrests Chinese citizen for spying",
2026-05-18, [Link](#)**

- **Norway's PST arrested two Chinese nationals for espionage within weeks:** A man detained in Nordland on May 15 joins a woman arrested May 7 for suspected satellite data surveillance.
- **Woman's case linked to Chinese polar-orbit satellite interception infrastructure:** PST said a Norwegian-registered company served as suspected cover to establish a satellite receiving station, with further suspects sought.

**Bloomberg: "Marcos says Philippines would be involved in any
Taiwan conflict", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)**

- **Marcos cited geography and diaspora as explanation for Philippines' Taiwan entanglement:** Proximity and nearly 200,000 Filipinos living in Taiwan mean the country cannot stay out of any conflict, he said.
- **Philippines-Japan security talks to address Tokyo's newly eased defence export rules:** Marcos heads to Tokyo next week for talks with PM Takaichi on regional security following Japan's liberalised arms export policy.
- **China's MFA rejected Marcos' geographic rationale for Taiwan involvement:** Spokesman Guo Jiakun said proximity does not justify interference in "another country's internal and sovereign affairs."

WSJ: "The hidden Chinese influence in AI", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **State media dominates Chinese-language AI training corpora:** Researchers found Chinese state media is 41 times more prevalent than Wikipedia in CulturaX, comprising roughly one in four politically sensitive documents mentioning Xi or Party bodies.
- **Chatbots answer China-sensitive questions more favourably in Chinese:** Annotators judged Chinese-language responses more pro-Beijing in 75.3% of paired comparisons across GPT, Claude, Gemini, and Grok, a peer-reviewed Nature study reports.
- **Press freedom predicts local-language AI pro-government bias:** The pattern holds across 37 countries, amplified by the asymmetry between freely available state media and paywalled independent outlets, the researchers argue.

**SCMP: "Could China limit Japanese airlines' access to its airspace
as ties sour?", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)**

- **Aviation professionals flag Chinese airspace as a potential retaliatory lever:** Restricting Japanese overflights would disrupt Japan-Europe routes more severely than current flight cancellations, pilots warned SCMP.
- **Tensions follow Takaichi's November remarks on Taiwan defense:** Beijing has already cancelled flights and issued travel advisories; full airspace closure is seen as unlikely as it would also disrupt Chinese carriers.

FT: "The US and China crave hegemony without responsibility", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **China has not filled the global leadership vacuum:** The author argues Beijing calls for stability during crises but avoids the costs, with its foreign aid budget a fraction of historical US levels.
- **52 of 70 major economies launched trade defence measures targeting China last year:** The article cites MERICS data to show Beijing's economic policies face broad global blowback, constraining its claim to represent an alternative order.

WSJ: "Xi Jinping is now the world leader he wanted to be, but it has come at a cost", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Xi stages back-to-back summits with Trump and Putin in one month:** No Chinese leader has previously hosted both sitting presidents in the same month, marking what the article calls a watershed moment.
- **China's export-dominant industries nearly doubled from 192 to 315 in three years:** A US Chamber of Commerce and Rhodium Group study found China dominates more than half of global exports in 315 industries.
- **Putin arrives in Beijing as Russia's reliance on China has deepened:** He must confirm no undisclosed Xi-Trump understandings and secure continued Chinese oil purchases and military components, analysts say.

FT: "China's Xi Jinping warns of 'law of the jungle' at summit with Vladimir Putin", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Kremlin confirmed ~40 bilateral documents and a 47-page joint statement:** The agreements accompany Putin's Beijing summit as Russia's energy export revenues fell 38% year-on-year and its budget deficit widened, according to FT.
- **Xi reportedly told Trump Putin might regret the Ukraine invasion:** China's foreign ministry and Trump denied the account, which emerged from US officials' assessment of the Beijing summit held days before Putin's arrival.

SCMP: "Will US defence strategy architect Colby pave the way for Hegseth's China visit?", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Pentagon to send Elbridge Colby to Beijing to prepare Hegseth visit:** The undersecretary for policy is expected within weeks to finalise arrangements, following last week's Trump-Xi summit, according to sources.
- **Hegseth's Beijing visit ended eight-year US defence chief absence from China:** He was also the first American defence secretary to accompany a sitting president on a China state visit since 1970s normalisation, SCMP reports.

Diplomat: "Chinese experts read the Trump-Xi summit as a power-shift moment", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Survey of 50 Chinese commentaries shows overwhelming consensus on structural change:** Only six of 50 authors primarily emphasised fragility; most treated the détente as structural rather than tactical relief.

- **MSS-affiliated CICIR framed US-China ties as 'strategic stalemate' on summit day:** The influential think tank concluded relations now require a new framework of 'constructive strategic stability' suited to that condition.
- **Four of five analysts surveyed read Trump's Taiwan remarks as a concession to Beijing:** One called them the most Beijing-favorable US presidential statement on Taiwan in over 20 years.

Diplomat: "What actually caused the latest submarine cut near Taiwan?", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Salvage vessel's unusual route passed near Matsu cable infrastructure:** Taiwanese media attributed the April cut to the Hai Hong Gong 66 dredger, contradicting international reports citing weather-shifted wreckage.
- **Wrecked vessel had previously joined PLA civilian-military fusion drills:** The Min Lian Yu 63896, whose salvage prompted the cut, had participated in Maritime Militia exercises simulating quarantine maneuvers.
- **Taiwan's cable surveillance relies on AIS rather than real-time satellite tracking:** Budget shortfalls leave only 96 vessels blacklisted against militia drills involving potentially thousands of civilian ships.

Wire China: "The suppliant and the sovereign", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **China's Power of Siberia II leverage has strengthened:** Trump's return gave Xi a US LNG price anchor, the authors argue, reducing Beijing's incentive to accept Russian gas on Moscow's terms.
- **Arctic access identified as Russia's likely concession:** China already finances Northern Sea Route infrastructure, the authors note, making full Arctic power status a question of speed and terms rather than principle.
- **European security may become a function of Chinese calculations:** Beijing's hold over Russian energy finances gives it indirect influence over the pressure Moscow chooses to apply to European neighbours, the authors warn.

SCMP: "US casts Cuba as China-linked security threat while still pushing for talks", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Rubio cited Chinese and Russian intelligence and weapons presence in Cuba:** The Secretary of State framed the island as a proximate national security threat near Florida, according to SCMP.
- **Beijing condemned US criminal charges against Raul Castro:** China's foreign ministry urged Washington to stop "brandishing the sanctions stick" and reaffirmed support for Cuban sovereignty and non-interference.

SCMP: "'We really do not trust each other': former US envoy foresees wary new phase in China ties", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Baucus frames summit as mutual crisis prevention, not trust-building:** The former US ambassador said both sides want to stabilise the relationship but acknowledged "we really do not trust each other."

- **New "constructive strategic stability" language signals a holding pattern:** According to Baucus, the shared diplomatic framing points to conflict-avoidance, not the start of a durable reset.

Foreign Policy: "What Happened When Trump Met Xi", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **China's state media gave the summit minimal domestic coverage:** People's Daily placed commentary on page 3 and the main evening news allocated just 12 seconds to the visit, according to Mitter.
- **Treasury, not State, led the summit as Trump's trade focus sidelined China hawks:** Mitter argues Bessent's centrality reflects a Trump doctrine placing the bilateral trade deficit above strategic competition, Taiwan, and AI concerns.

Brookings: "Will Taiwanese accept Xi Jinping's version of 'One China'?", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Survey finds 47% of Taiwanese unclear on the 1992 Consensus:** Despite that ambiguity, 41% overall support Cheng Li-wun's slogan "1992 Consensus, oppose Taiwanese independence," the authors find.
- **KMT voters support consensus slogan but reject "one country, two systems":** 80% back Cheng's formulation while fewer than 40% support the framework Beijing explicitly links to it.
- **Authors warn of misinterpretation risk in Taiwanese consensus support:** Xi explicitly ties the 1992 Consensus to "one country, two systems," a connection most Taiwanese supporters of the slogan reject.

WSJ: "Iran's seizure of Chinese security ship shows its favors for friends have limits", 2026-05-16, [Link](#)

- **Iran detained a Chinese security firm's vessel near the Strait of Hormuz:** Sinoguards Marine Security confirmed the seizure, the first known incident involving a private-security ship since the US-Iran war began.
- **The seizure signals Iran will not extend armed-escort protection even to China:** According to WSJ, the incident - occurring on the same day as the Trump-Xi Beijing summit - suggests limits to Iran's tolerance for Chinese maritime security operations near the strait.

FT: "Xi Jinping told Donald Trump that Putin might 'regret' invasion of Ukraine", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Trump proposed US-China-Russia coalition against the ICC:** During Beijing talks, Trump told Xi that the three powers' interests were aligned and they should jointly oppose the International Criminal Court, per people familiar with the US assessment.
- **White House factsheet omitted Ukraine and ICC discussions entirely:** The administration's published account of the Beijing summit contained no mention of Putin, Ukraine, or the ICC proposal despite the wide-ranging talks reported.

**Lowy Institute: "Japan's quiet test of China diplomacy",
2026-05-20, [Link](#)**

- **Kikawada's Shanghai visit marked Japan's first cabinet-level presence in China since November:** The APEC Women and Economy forum gave Tokyo a multilateral setting to resume official contact without making bilateral political concessions.
- **Japan scheduled no separate bilateral ministerial meetings during the visit:** Tokyo sought to prevent Beijing from framing resumed contact as a retreat on Taiwan policy, the article reports.
- **Multiple Japanese delegations are queued for China through June:** Nishimura visited Beijing on 2 May, METI Minister Akazawa is headed to Suzhou, and a trade association delegation plans senior-official meetings.

Carnegie: "China's Pivot on Global AI", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Li Qiang unveiled a 13-point AI governance plan in July 2025:** The proposal introduced a world AI cooperation organization (WAICO) to anchor China's bid to reshape global AI governance norms.
- **Beijing's AI diplomacy is shifting from infrastructure exports to normative institution-building:** The author argues China now uses UN processes, informal bodies, and capacity-building centres to legitimize its state-centric AI model globally.
- **US retreat from AI norms bodies has opened space for Beijing:** Trump's withdrawal from multilateral institutions leaves China positioned to shape AI governance terms in the Global South, the author argues.

NYT: "Rubio, Once a China Hawk, Strikes Softer Tone to Align With Trump -- NYT", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Beijing resolved Rubio's sanction ban by distinguishing senator from cabinet roles:** China told the New York Times the 2020 sanctions targeted his senatorial rhetoric, not his current position, clearing his entry to the Beijing summit.
- **Rubio reframed his China stance from "near-peer adversary" to cooperation-seeking diplomat:** As secretary of state, he replaced human rights emphasis with strategic stability language, while the State Department has continued imposing China-related sanctions in practice.

Lowy Institute: "China's influence in Africa is no longer just economic", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **China excluded Eswatini from its zero-tariff Africa expansion:** Beijing extended duty-free access to every African country bar Taiwan's last diplomatic partner, tying market access to One China compliance.
- **Chinese pressure allegedly caused postponement of Zambia's RightsCon conference:** Beijing reportedly objected to Taiwanese civil society participants, the article reports, pushing Chinese leverage into civic and political space inside an African state.

- **Author argues China's Africa influence now extends beyond economics:** Beijing shapes diplomatic behaviour, civic access, and political incentives - not just infrastructure and trade - according to the article.

Foreign Policy: "No Limits, No Good Options", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Power of Siberia 2 pipeline saw no agreement at the summit:** Putin left Beijing without a deal as China maintains leverage over Russia's gas pricing and take-or-pay terms.
- **Chinese car brands captured 57% of Russia's new-vehicle market by 2025:** The share tripled from under 20% in 2022 as Chinese firms absorbed factories vacated by Western manufacturers.
- **Author argues Russia's post-war leverage will only weaken:** Deepened Chinese trade and technology ties during the conflict leave Moscow with diminishing room to seek alternative partners once hostilities end.

Foreign Policy: "Xi's Flurry of Post-Trump Diplomacy", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **China's potential Pyongyang visit aims to offset Russia-NK axis:** Analysts argue Beijing risks losing leverage over North Korea after Kim and Putin signed a mutual defense pact in 2024, with Chinese fears over Russian weapons transfers adding urgency.
- **North Korea negotiates from a position of confidence, not desperation:** Crypto cyber-heists worth billions have reduced Pyongyang's financial vulnerability, leaving it seeking equal - not junior-partner - status, former Biden NSC official Rapp-Hooper argues.
- **Analysts frame Beijing as 2026's diplomatic center of gravity:** Brookings' Ryan Hass argues China is accumulating diplomatic capital by contrasting its predictability with US unpredictability, sequencing Trump and Putin summits to project global leadership.

Brookings: "What Beijing got from the Trump-Xi summit", 2026-05-22, [Link](#)

- **Scholars argue Beijing withheld commercial wins deliberately:** Brookings analysts say China felt no need to offer visiting CEOs market access or rare earth deals, projecting confidence and substantial leverage over Washington.
- **"Constructive strategic stability" framed as a trap for US allies:** Czin argues Beijing chose the phrase to signal to Tokyo, Seoul, and Taipei that Washington is now prioritising stability with China over its alliance commitments.
- **Trump's post-departure remarks handed Beijing additional gains:** Scholars say his weekend comments on negotiating Taiwan arms sales and adopting China's new bilateral framework exceeded what Beijing had secured at the summit itself.

FT: "Donald Trump undecided on Taiwan arms sale after summit with Xi Jinping", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **Xi formulated "constructive strategic stability" across four operational pillars:** Co-operation as the mainstay, competition within limits, manageable

differences, and predictable peace - framed as strategic guidance for three years and beyond, per China's MFA readout.

- **Trump asserted Xi offered Iran mediation; Chinese state media omitted the claim:** The US president said Xi called for reopening the Strait of Hormuz and volunteered to help broker a conflict resolution, an exchange Beijing's official coverage did not report.

Nikkei: "'Taiwan independence' means we don't belong to Beijing, president says", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **Lai redefined "Taiwan independence" as non-subordination, not formal secession:** At the DPP's 40th anniversary, he said the term means only that the ROC and PRC are not subordinate to each other.
- **Remarks followed Trump-Xi summit doubts about US backing:** Trump said after meeting Xi he did not want Taiwan emboldened toward independence due to US support, and had yet to decide on further arms sales.

5. Strategic implications and responses

NYT: "From Tesla to Visa, CEOs on Trump's China Trip Sought Relief", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Beijing has quietly blocked Suzhou Maxwell exports of high-end solar manufacturing equipment to Tesla (~\$3bn intended buy for US solar+storage build-out):** Musk reportedly went seeking to unblock; no public sign of success.
- **Specific bottlenecks across delegation:** Coherent blocked from buying indium phosphide; H200 sales to China still unapproved; Illumina remains on "unreliable entity list"; Meta ordered to unwind Manus acquisition; Micron deemed security risk; Visa still denied independent RMB settlement license despite WTO ruling; BlackRock CK Hutchison ports bid faces objections; GE Aerospace rare-earth supply for engines disrupted.
- **CEO list assembled at the last minute (final group on Air Force One pickup in Alaska for Jensen Huang):** Navarro publicly dismissed delegation as "useful idiots". Few public deliverables beyond Boeing 200-plane MOU (below pre-summit ~500 expectation) and reported moves to approve Citi securities-firm application.

Brookings: "Trump's dangerous Taiwan gamble", 2026-05-16, [Link](#)

- **Hass: Trump's post-summit framing aligned with PRC preferences on three points – "not looking to have Taiwan go independent", Taiwan must "cool down", \$14B arms sale "leverage" with Xi:** Author argues this places Trump apart from his own administration's working assumption that PRC pressure (not Taiwan or US action) drives current tensions.
- **The "horse already sold" problem:** Beijing views the 1982 Third Communiqué as having locked in US arms-sales reduction over time; any new US "concession" on arms is one Beijing believes it already secured. Net effect: US credibility loss without Chinese reciprocation.
- **Policy prescription is restraint, not retreat:** Sustain deterrence; resist unilateral moves from either side; encourage cross-Strait dialogue while

preserving influence in both Beijing and Taipei. Trump's "matador's red flag" framing of Taiwan as bargaining chip raises – not lowers – conflict risk.

Reuters: "Bessent says G7 aims to confront China with imbalances data", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **G7 finance ministers used IMF data to formally confront Beijing on export-driven imbalances:** Bessent positioned the US tariff wall as forcing high-end Chinese goods toward EU/UK/Aus/Can/Japan and said his prior warnings to allies "unfortunately, I was right".
- **Bessent flagged Iran sanctions enforcement gaps:** Europe to close Iranian bank branches; Asian states to police the shadow tanker fleet preventing ship-to-ship transfers to non-sanctioned vessels.

Euronews: "As trade war with China looms, how can the EU defend itself?", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **EU-China surplus rose \$22bn year-on-year in early 2026:** Chinese customs data show China ran a \$113 billion surplus with the EU-27 in January-April 2026, up from \$91 billion in the same period of 2025.
- **Commission set to debate five China trade tools on 29 May:** Options include supplier diversification thresholds (30-40% cap), sector-specific tariffs, anti-dumping duties, and the Anti-Coercion Instrument as a last resort.
- **Member state divisions risk undermining a unified EU stance:** Germany and Spain have resisted tougher measures, while Beijing has threatened retaliation over EU laws limiting Chinese firms' access to the single market.

NYT: "Trump's Taiwan Gambit is Already a Gift to China - The New York Times", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Trump held \$14bn Taiwan arms sale "in abeyance" after Beijing summit:** The US president told Fox News the package was a "very good negotiating chip" to be used with China, without specifying what he wanted in return.
- **Chinese state media used Trump's comments to cast doubt on US security guarantees:** Global Times cited a researcher warning Taiwan's DPP government can no longer count on "unconditional indulgence" from Washington.
- **Analysts warn a prolonged hold would erode US deterrence credibility:** A Foundation for Defense of Democracies analyst said a delay shaped by Beijing's objections would raise "much more serious concerns about the reliability of U.S. deterrence."

FT: "America needs to put the renminbi back on the international agenda", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Authors estimate renminbi undervaluation at roughly 20%:** China's manufacturing surplus - over 10% of GDP and close to 1% of world GDP - is the largest any single country has run in 70-plus years, the article reports.
- **Trump-Xi summit did not address exchange rates:** The authors argue the administration has focused on tariffs and managed trade while remaining publicly silent on renminbi valuation, leaving the structural imbalance unaddressed.

- **Authors urge G7 and IMF to jointly press Beijing for currency appreciation:** With US tariffs risk redirecting Chinese export surpluses toward Europe, the piece argues shared interests now outweigh European concerns about Beijing retaliation.

SCMP: "Australia orders Chinese investors to sell rare earth stakes", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Australia ordered six China-linked entities in Northern Minerals to divest:** Five are registered in China or Hong Kong; all six together hold 27% of the A\$229 million rare earths firm.
- **The order is Canberra's second Northern Minerals divestment in two years:** Australia sued a Chinese company for breaching a 2024 order and won the case last year.

FT: "Defence groups clamour to delay US ban on Chinese rare earth magnets", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **US defence firms seek delay on Chinese magnet ban:** Companies are lobbying Congress to extend the January 2027 deadline barring Pentagon contracts from using Chinese-sourced rare earth magnets.
- **CSIS warns 2027 deadline may outpace supply chain build-out:** The think tank found that significantly more non-Chinese magnet capacity must come online within eight months for compliance to be feasible.

SCMP: "Milei guts China currency lifeline after Trump ultimatum on financial ties: reports", 2026-05-19, [Link](#)

- **Argentina's China currency swap balance fell from \$5bn to \$675m:** Buenos Aires has repaid nearly 90% of the activated tranche, with full settlement expected by mid-2026, according to central bank records.
- **Washington reportedly pressed Buenos Aires to wind down the China swap:** The repayment covers only the activated portion; the full \$19 billion framework agreement signed in 2009 and renewed in 2023 remains in place.

SCMP: "Japan plans island drone deployment to monitor Chinese naval activity", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **SeaGuardian drones to fill a Pacific surveillance gap:** Japan will station US-built drones on Iwo Jima, Chichijima, and Minamitorishima, covering an area government sources described as a real-time intelligence blind spot.
- **Chinese warships now operating beyond Japan's first island chain:** Japanese defence assessments and an ICG analyst cited expanded PLA Navy activity east of Okinawa as the primary driver of the deployment decision.

Straits Times: "EU Parliament adopts higher tariffs on foreign steel to battle China's cheap exports", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **EU Parliament votes 606-16 to double steel import tariffs to 50%:** Tariff-free quotas are cut 47% to 18.3 million tonnes - the 2013 import level before Chinese overcapacity distorted the market; measures take effect July 1.
- **UK calls for EU-UK steel alliance as Starmer moves to nationalise British Steel:** British trade minister Bryant sought coordinated market access with Brussels while the UK government separately legislated to take over the Chinese-owned steelmaker.

Politico: "Trump says he'll talk to Taiwan's president amid arms deal negotiations", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **Trump signals direct call with Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te:** A call would overturn nearly five decades of diplomatic practice under which US-Taiwan ties are conducted exclusively through non-official outposts.
- **Trump confirmed discussing Taiwan arms sales with Xi, violating a longstanding US prohibition:** Consulting Beijing on such transfers breaks established US policy, and withholding the sale would additionally breach the 1979 Taiwan Relations Act.

NYT: "Eager for Arms Deal, Taiwan Stresses Need for U.S. Support - The New York Times", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Lai called US arms sales "indispensable" for regional stability:** Taiwan's president responded publicly after Trump disclosed he had discussed the \$14bn package with Xi, calling continued weapons sales a "vital element" for peace.
- **US trade representative said there was "no change" in Taiwan policy:** Greer's ABC appearance appeared to walk back Trump's earlier disclosure that he had discussed the arms package with Xi Jinping in "great detail."

ECFR: "How China's silent coercion has Europe sanctioning itself", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Author argues Chinese coercion works through EU pre-emptive self-censorship:** Beijing need not activate its coercive tools if European policymakers drop policies to avoid retaliation, the ECFR paper argues.
- **China's April rules can penalise EU firms for obeying EU law:** Companies with Chinese business ties risk sanctions under Beijing's supply chain security regulations for complying with EU-mandated supplier diversification, the author reports.
- **Author calls for combined EU trade defence and deterrence agenda:** Addressing China's systemic price distortions will inevitably trigger coercive retaliation, the author argues, making industrial protection and economic deterrence inseparable policy goals.

CFR: "China and the U.S. Agreed to 'Strategic Stability' in Beijing. They Don't Define It the Same Way.", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **Readouts diverged on the meaning of "strategic stability":** Washington used the phrase to signal economic risk reduction; Beijing tied it to core interests, the three joint communiqués, and recognition of China's development path, the author argues.
- **Taiwan absent from US fact sheet but central to China's readout:** Xi reportedly called Taiwan the "most important issue" in bilateral relations; its omission from the White House document illustrates the gap in what each side considers stability to require.
- **New bilateral boards exclude contested technology and security issues by design:** The author argues the mechanisms are built for commercial disputes only, keeping semiconductors, AI, export controls, and Taiwan outside the room.

Bloomberg: "US to Mull Action If China Overcapacity Found, Trade Envoy Says - Bloomberg", 2026-05-18, [Link](#)

- **If overcapacity probes confirm concerns, Trump will receive action options:** USTR Greer told CBS investigations could justify tariffs, service fees, or quotas on Chinese goods.
- **Supreme Court tariff ruling pushed the US toward conventional trade probes:** After the court struck down Trump's global tariffs in February, the administration shifted to country-specific investigations authorising targeted measures.

Bloomberg: "EU Seeks to Lift Ban on Chinese Chips It Barred Only Weeks Ago - Bloomberg", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **Commission to propose exemption for Chinese chipmaker on Russia sanctions list:** Yangjie was listed in April after its components appeared in Russian drones and glide bombs; member state approval is required for any derogation.
- **European automakers lobbied for relief citing weeks until stock depletion:** Producers said supply chain diversification was incomplete; the temporary exemption is expected to last several months to allow alternative sourcing.

Wire China: "TP-Link's American Dream", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **FCC banned all foreign-made consumer routers in March:** The country-agnostic rule effectively targets TP-Link, which holds over 60% of the US consumer router market, according to the article.
- **Commerce shelved an internal TP-Link ban recommendation:** An undersecretary sat on an office-level determination recommending a product ban, citing concerns about disrupting the US-China trade truce.
- **Researchers argue domestic manufacturing does not address core router security risks:** Cybersecurity experts quoted say outdated firmware and default passwords make US-made routers equally exploitable as Chinese-made devices.

CFR: "The AI Balance of Power", 2026-05-20, [Link](#)

- **US and China dominate global AI compute, holding 90% of GPU cluster performance:** As of May 2025, the US held 75% and China 15% of GPU cluster performance; China separately trains roughly half of the world's top-tier AI researchers.
- **US private AI investment hit \$109bn in 2024 against \$3.3bn in public funding:** OpenAI researchers noted private spending likely exceeds the military R&D budgets of nearly every country, with frontier labs holding superior insight into model capabilities and risks.
- **China's military-civil fusion contrasts with the unresolved US public-private AI governance split:** The article argues the CCP's command over tech firms gives Beijing a structural advantage, while the 2025-26 Anthropic-Pentagon dispute exposed an unresolved question of who governs American AI.

EUISS: "Joris Teer's Chaillot Paper featured in various media outlets", 2026-05-21, [Link](#)

- **EU set CRM production targets without policies to fund them:** The Chaillot Paper argues Europe has designated strategic projects but failed to adopt financially viable frameworks to compete with China's state-sponsored supply chains.
- **Paper proposes "allied industrial bloc" over trading-partner reliance:** Rather than treating China as a trade partner, the author calls for restructuring critical raw material sourcing around allied supply networks to reduce leverage exposure.

IV. Wochenbericht CN-Medien

Caveat: nur stichprobenartig auf Qualität/Richtigkeit überprüft – Coverage nur bis 22.05.

1. Prominente Zitate und Positionen zu China-bezogenen Angelegenheiten

- Wladimir Putin bezeichnete die russisch-chinesischen Beziehungen am Dienstag vor seinem Besuch in Peking als auf einem „beispiellosen Niveau“ befindlich. (Source: „Putin lobt Beziehungen zu China“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 20. Mai 2026).
- Ursula von der Leyen betonte am Freitag anlässlich des Abkommens mit Mexiko, dass Europa wirtschaftlich enger mit Partnern zusammenrücken müsse, um sich in einer Welt „kompetitiver Geopolitik“ zu behaupten. (Source: „URSULA VON DER LEYEN, CLAUDIA SHEINBAUM; Neue Nähe“, Handelsblatt, 22. Mai 2026).
- Dorothee Bär (Forschungsministerin, CSU) stellte am Donnerstag die neuen „Roadmaps“ der Hightech-Agenda vor und erklärte: „Innovation ist unsere neue Standortpolitik“, um technologische Souveränität gegenüber China zu sichern. (Source: „HIGHTECH-AGENDA; Volle Kraft voraus“, faz.net, 21. Mai 2026).

- Norbert Röttgen (Unionsfraktionsvize, CDU) warnte am Donnerstag vor Pekings unfairer Wettbewerb: „Schon seit Jahren verfolgt China einen aggressiven wirtschaftlichen Expansionskurs auf Kosten Europas.“ (Source: „EXPORTE; China-Schock alarmiert deutsche Politik“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026).
- Franziska Brantner (Staatssekretärin im Wirtschaftsministerium, Grüne) forderte am Donnerstag eine klare handelspolitische Linie: „Es braucht eine harte Durchsetzung europäischer Plattformregeln gegenüber Anbietern wie Temu und Shein.“ (Source: „EXPORTE; China-Schock alarmiert deutsche Politik“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026).
- Wolfgang Hattmannsdorfer (Wirtschaftsminister Österreichs) betonte am Mittwoch, dass man von seiner Industriestrategie lernen könne, um dem chinesischen Druck standzuhalten: „Deutschland kann von uns lernen.“ (Source: „WOLFGANG HATTMANNSDORFER; „Deutschland kann von unserer Industriestrategie lernen““, Factiva, 20. Mai 2026).
- Monika Schnitzer (Wirtschaftsweise) kritisierte am Mittwoch nationale Sonderwege in Europa: „Berlin fordert Wettbewerbsfähigkeit, verteidigt aber nationale Sonderwege. Führung hieße: echte europäische Märkte ermöglichen.“ (Source: „HOMO OECONOMICUS; Europas größtes Problem ist nicht China“, Handelsblatt, 20. Mai 2026).
- Björn Gulden (Vorstandschef Adidas) verteidigte am Freitag, den 15. Mai 2026, seine Führungsstrategie und betonte mit Blick auf Fernost: „Ich vertraue dem Team in China! Anders bekommst du die kreativen Talente auch gar nicht mehr.“ (Source: „Adidas-Chef; „Ich werde nicht an meinem Stuhl kleben““, wiwo.de, 15. Mai 2026).
- Claudia Major (Sicherheitsexpertin) warnte am Donnerstag vor strukturellen Problemen in Europa, falls zentrale Akteure die Bedrohung durch Russland und dessen Verbündete nicht mehr ernst nähmen. (Source: „EUROPÄISCHE UNION; Europas neue Bewährungsprobe“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026).
- Marek Kohv (Sicherheitsexperte) erklärte am Donnerstag zur Bedrohungslage im Baltikum durch die China-Russland-Achse: „Wir haben nicht den Luxus abzuwarten.“ (Source: „„Wir haben nicht den Luxus abzuwarten““, taz - die tageszeitung, 21. Mai 2026).
- Daniela Schwarzer (Bertelsmann Stiftung) warnte am Mittwoch in einem Gastbeitrag vor der Verfestigung einer „antiwestlichen Achse“ durch die Gipfeltreffen von Putin und Xi. (Source: „Goeconomics; Europa unterliegt einer gefährlichen Illusion“, handelsblatt.com, 20. Mai 2026).
- Stefan Meister (DGAP) konstatierte am Dienstag, dass China und Russland enge Verbündete gegenüber den USA seien und sich das Machtgefüge hinter der inszenierten Harmonie deutlich verschiebe. (Source: „XI JINPING, WLADIMIR PUTIN; Zweckbündnis gegen den Westen“, Handelsblatt, 20. Mai 2026).
- Rebecca Boucsein (FAZ-Autorin) berichtete am Dienstag, dass Moskau und Peking ihre „strategische Koordinierung“ vertiefen wollten, um sich den US-Präsidenten Trump zunutze zu machen. (Source: „Nach Trump besucht auch Putin Xi“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 19. Mai 2026).
- Ola Källenius (Mercedes-Benz-Chef) betonte laut Bericht vom Dienstag die Stärken deutscher Hersteller: „Was Autohersteller außergewöhnlich gut können, ist es, hochwertige Präzisionsmaschinen in größeren Stückzahlen zu bauen.“ (Source: „DEFENSE CIRCLE; Panzer statt Autos“, Handelsblatt, 19. Mai 2026).
- Cord Schellenberg (Luftfahrtexperte) konstatierte am Donnerstag zum technologischen Aufstieg Pekings: „China hat die Chance, seine nationale Luftfahrtindustrie auf Weltniveau zu bringen.“ (Source: „Asia Techonomics;

- Chinas größter Flugzeugbauer kann Airbus noch nicht ersetzen“, handelsblatt.com, 21. Mai 2026).
- Tanjeff Schadt (Chipexperte) stellte am Dienstag fest, dass Europa bei der Halbleiterfertigung umdenken müsse: „In anderen Regionen ist ein Anteil an lokaler Produktion längst vorgeschrieben.“ (Source: „AKTIE IM BLICK; KI-Turbo treibt Infineon an die Dax-Spitze“, faz.net, 21. Mai 2026).
 - Alexander Gerst (Astronaut) bezeichnete den Mond am Mittwoch im Rahmen des Artemis-Programms als „offenes Geschichtsbuch“, das im Wettlauf mit China neu erkundet werden müsse. (Source: „ALEXANDER GERST; "Der Mond ist wie ein offenes Geschichtsbuch"“, faz.net, 20. Mai 2026).
 - Nikolas Busse (Herausgeber FAZ) konstatierte am Donnerstag, den 21. Mai 2026, dass kein Land so von den Fehlern anderer profitiert habe wie China und bezeichnete den Besuch Putins als eine „Parade der Bittsteller in Peking“. (Source: „Bittsteller in Peking“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 21. Mai 2026).
 - Christian Kullmann (Vorstandschef Evonik) warnte am Mittwoch, dass die aktuelle Importschwemme aus China zwar ebbt, die chinesische Chemie aber „mit Wucht nach Europa zurückkommen“ wird. (Source: „Evonik-Chef; „Chinas Chemie wird mit Wucht nach Europa zurückkommen““, handelsblatt.com, 20. Mai 2026).
 - Thomas Sigmund (Handelsblatt-Redakteur) bezeichnete die Pläne zur Fertigung chinesischer E-Autos in VW-Werken am Dienstag als industriepolitisches Alarmsignal, das eine „fatale Rollenteilung“ einläute. (Source: „PRO & CONTRA; Wird Deutschland zur Werkbank Chinas?“, Handelsblatt, 19. Mai 2026).
 - Jens Münchrath (Handelsblatt-Redakteur) argumentierte am Dienstag, dass chinesische Investitionen in Europa ein Zeichen der Stärke und Hilfe sein können und der Technologietransfer „kein Makel“ sein müsse. (Source: „PRO & CONTRA; Wird Deutschland zur Werkbank Chinas?“, Handelsblatt, 19. Mai 2026).
 - Holger Appel (FAZ-Redakteur) bezeichnete am Dienstag den Import chinesisch entwickelter Elektroautos unter der Marke Opel als eine Mischung aus „Erdrutsch und Weckruf“. (Source: „Leapesgrüße aus Hangzhou“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 19. Mai 2026).
 - Michael Hüther (IW Köln) forderte am Donnerstag eine Rückbesinnung auf die Angebotspolitik, um den Standort Deutschland gegen den Druck aus China und den USA zu stärken. (Source: „WIRTSCHAFTSPOLITIK; Auch nach 50 Jahren: Über die Angebotsseite nach vorne“, faz.net, 21. Mai 2026).

2. Wichtige China-bezogenen Entwicklungen in Fakten und Zahlen

- China bleibt Deutschlands wichtigster Handelspartner: Im ersten Quartal 2026 belief sich der Warenaustausch mit der Volksrepublik auf insgesamt 61,5 Milliarden Euro, womit China weiterhin vor den USA liegt. (Source: „China bleibt Deutschlands größter Handelspartner“, Der Tagesspiegel, 21. Mai 2026).
- Gipfel der „asymmetrischen Freundschaft“: Beim Besuch Putins in Peking am 20. Mai wurde die über 4.300 Kilometer lange gemeinsame Grenze als Symbol der Kooperation beschworen, während Russland wirtschaftlich immer abhängiger von China wird. (Source: „Staatsbesuch in Peking; Putin lobt »positive Dynamik«“, zeit.de, 20. Mai 2026).
- Varta-Werksschließung infolge von China-Konkurrenz: Der Batteriehersteller schließt seinen Standort in Nördlingen (Bayern), da Großkunde Apple

Knopfbatterien künftig aus China bezieht. Rund 350 Menschen verlieren ihren Job. (Source: „Weil Apple in China kauft! Varta schließt Standort“, BILD Hannover, 20. Mai 2026).

- Nvidia mit explosivem Umsatzplus: Der KI-Chippgigant meldete einen Quartalsumsatz von 81 Milliarden Dollar, was die enorme globale Nachfrage unterstreicht, von der auch asiatische Zulieferer profitieren. (Source: „Nvidia macht 81 Milliarden Dollar Umsatz in drei Monaten“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 20. Mai 2026).
- Verdoppelung der EU-Stahlzölle: Das Europaparlament hat am 19. Mai beschlossen, Importe aus Drittstaaten wie China ab Juli mit einem Zollsatz von 50 Prozent zu belegen, um die heimische Industrie vor Billigkonkurrenz zu schützen. (Source: „Die EU verdoppelt ihre Zölle auf Stahl“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 20. Mai 2026).
- Enthüllung geheimer Militärausbildung: Geheimdokumente belegen laut Bericht vom 20. Mai, dass China im Verborgenen russische Soldaten für den Einsatz im Ukraine-Krieg ausgebildet hat. (Source: „China bildet Putins Soldaten für den Ukraine-Krieg aus“, Die Welt, 20. Mai 2026).
- Überkapazitäten bei Volkswagen: In den deutschen VW-Werken liegen die Überkapazitäten derzeit bei rund einer Million Fahrzeugen pro Jahr, was die Debatte über eine Produktion chinesischer Modelle in Deutschland befeuert. (Source: „AUTOBAUER; Tabubruch in Wolfsburg möglich“, Handelsblatt, 19. Mai 2026).
- China-Boom im deutschen Depot: US-Präsident Trump stockte vor seiner China-Reise Positionen von Apple, Tesla und Nvidia in seinem Depot um bis zu 7,2 Millionen Dollar auf. (Source: „Auffällige Verschiebungen im „Trump-Depot“, Die Welt, 20. Mai 2026).
- Direktinvestitionen in Europa steigen: Chinesische Firmen erhöhten ihre Direktinvestitionen in Europa im Jahr 2025 um 67 Prozent, primär getrieben durch den Bau lokaler Fabriken im Automobilsektor. (Source: „Handelskonflikt; China baut in Europa so viele Fabriken wie nie zuvor“, handelsblatt.com, 18. Mai 2026).
- DIW-Studie zur Innovationsschwäche: Deutschlands Anteil an forschungsintensiven Gütern schrumpft seit über zehn Jahren, während Chinas Weltmarktanteile in diesen Sektoren massiv zunehmen. (Source: „DIW-Studie; Deutschlands forschungsintensive Industrien verlieren Weltmarktanteile“, handelsblatt.com, 20. Mai 2026).
- Militärausgaben-Explosion unter Xi: Chinas Verteidigungshaushalt stieg in der Amtszeit von Xi Jinping von 130 auf 280 Milliarden Euro an. (Source: „Russland made in China“, taz - die tageszeitung, 19. Mai 2026).
- Quantencomputing-Offensive der USA: Die Trump-Regierung investiert zwei Milliarden Dollar in Quanten-Start-ups, um den technologischen Vorsprung gegenüber Pekings Quanten-Forschung zu halten. (Source: „US-INDUSTRIEPOLITIK; Die Trump-Regierung wird Quanteninvestor“, faz.net, 21. Mai 2026).
- Sicherheitsrisiko Exzellenz-Unis: An der RWTH Aachen forschen derzeit 4.000 chinesische Wissenschaftler, was laut Verfassungsschutz gezielte Abgreifversuche militärisch nutzbarer Technologie befürchten lässt. (Source: „CHINA-SPIONAGE; Spionagefall erschüttert Universitäten“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026).

3. Fünf zentrale Themen in der deutschen China-Politik Diskussion

- Die „asymmetrische Freundschaft“ – Russland als Chinas Juniorpartner: Der Staatsbesuch Putins in Peking unmittelbar nach der Visite Trumps dominiert die Berichterstattung. Deutsche Medien analysieren die Verschiebung des Machtgefüges: Russland ist in fast jeder Hinsicht (Energie, Drohnen-Komponenten, Währung) von China abhängig geworden. Die Allianz wird als „Zweckbündnis gegen den Westen“ gewertet, in dem Peking die Bedingungen diktiert und Russland als Rohstofflieferant und geostrategischer Puffer fungiert, während Xi Jinping sich als „Hüter der Stabilität“ gegenüber Washington inszeniert. Prominente Quellen: „PUTIN BEI XI JINPING; Die Parade der Bittsteller in Peking“, faz.net, 20. Mai 2026; „Wladimir Putin in China; Das Machtverhältnis hat sich längst gedreht“, zeit.de, 20. Mai 2026; „XI UND PUTIN; „Stabilität“ als Code für eine Welt ohne US-Führung“, Handelsblatt, 20. Mai 2026.
- Das „Fanal von Nördlingen“ – Die Brutalität globaler Lieferketten: Die Schließung des Varta-Werks, weil Apple seine Batterien künftig lieber in China bezieht, wird als Wendepunkt für den deutschen Mittelstand diskutiert. Es entbrennt eine Debatte über das Versagen der bisherigen Industriepolitik: Trotz Millionen an staatlichen Förderungen zieht der Weltmarktführer weiter nach Asien. Der Fall symbolisiert die Zerreißprobe zwischen Profitinteressen globaler Tech-Riesen und dem Erhalt hiesiger Hochtechnologie-Arbeitsplätze. Prominente Quellen: „Weil Apple in China kauft! Varta schließt Standort“, BILD Hannover, 20. Mai 2026; „Erst kamen die Staatsmillionen, jetzt der Stellenabbau“, Süddeutsche Zeitung, 21. Mai 2026; „Batteriehersteller; Varta schließt Werk in Nördlingen“, wiwo.de, 19. Mai 2026.
- Quanten-Geopolitik – Der neue Billionen-Dollar-Wettlauf: Nach dem KI-Boom rückt Quantencomputing als neues strategisches Schlachtfeld in den Fokus. Die US-Regierung unter Trump reagiert auf Pekings massive Fortschritte mit einem Zwei-Milliarden-Dollar-Paket für IBM und Start-ups. In Deutschland wird alarmiert debattiert, dass Europa in diesem „Trillion-Dollar-Arms-Race“ zwischen den USA und China erneut als „Zuschauer“ zurückzubleiben droht, während die Bundesregierung erst mühsam erste Roadmaps für Schlüsseltechnologien erstellt. Prominente Quellen: „US-INDUSTRIE POLITIK; Die Trump-Regierung wird Quanteninvestor“, faz.net, 21. Mai 2026; „KÜNSTLICHE INTELLIGENZ; Deutsche Spitzenchips für Europas digitale Souveränität“, faz.net, 19. Mai 2026; „HIGHTECH-AGENDA; Ambitionierter Traum“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026.
- Die „Workbench“-Debatte – Verlust der technologischen Seele: Ein kontroverses Thema ist der Einstieg chinesischer Hersteller in deutsche Fabriken (z. B. VW-Pläne oder Opel/Stellantis). Die Diskussion dreht sich um eine fatale Rollenteilung: China entwickelt die Software und die Plattformen, während Deutschland nur noch die „Blechkülsen“ zusammenschweißt. Kritiker warnen vor einem massiven Wissenstransfer in die falsche Richtung und fordern eine Rückbesinnung auf „Engineering made in Germany“, um nicht zum reinen Fertigungsstandort für chinesische Innovationen herabzusinken. Prominente Quellen: „PRO & CONTRA; Fatale Rollenteilung – China entwickelt, Deutschland schraubt“, Handelsblatt, 19. Mai 2026; „Produktion in Deutschland; Übernimmt China jetzt deutsche Autofabriken?“, zeit.de, 18. Mai 2026; „AUTOMARKT IM WANDEL; Leapesgrüße aus Hangzhou“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 19. Mai 2026.

- Wissenschaftssicherheit und diplomatische Erpressung an Hochschulen: Ein neues Eskalationsniveau in der Debatte um den Know-how-Abfluss wird durch den Fall der TU Berlin markiert, die eine Uiguren-Informationsveranstaltung nach Druck der chinesischen Botschaft absagte. Die Diskussion thematisiert die wachsende Naivität und Erpressbarkeit deutscher Hochschulen. Gleichzeitig fordern Politiker wie Kiesewetter ein Ende der „einseitigen strategischen Partnerschaft“ und ein Verbot von Forschungskooperationen in sensiblen Bereichen, um Spionage (Fall Aachen) zu verhindern. Prominente Quellen: „Uiguren-Unterstützer unter Druck“, taz - die tageszeitung, 21. Mai 2026; „CHINA-SPIONAGE; Spionagefall erschüttert Universitäten“, Handelsblatt, 21. Mai 2026; „China-Spionage; Spionagefall erschüttert deutsche Forschungseinrichtungen“, handelsblatt.com, 20. Mai 2026.